



TENSION

GAUNTLET

VOL. I : WHISPERS BELOW



MANTA

ANCHORITE DIVE UNIT

DEPTH RATING: 10,000M

CREW:
RENN
SLOANE
BIX
ECHO



ONE LEASH. ONE BREATH. ONE RETURN.



OUTSIDE THE MANTA.
DEPTH: 7,812 METERS.

PRESSURE EQUALIZED.
SILT THICK. VISIBILITY
LESS THAN FIVE METERS.

OOH, LOOKIT
HER DOWN
THERE.

STILL PRETTY,
EVEN COVERED
IN MUD.

FOCUS,
RENN.

W-WE'RE
NOT GONNA
GET PULLED
DOWN HERE,
RIGHT?

NOT IF WE
KEEP MOVING,
BIX.

I-I MEAN,
THE PRESSURE,
I FEEL IT IN MY
EARS AN' MY
TEETH AN'—

—AN' WHAT
IF SOMETHIN'
HUGE JUST
SHOWS UP
OUTTA NOWHERE?

THEN WE
ADAPT.
THAT'S WHY
WE TRAIN.

FEAR IS
ECHO.
RECOGNIZE.
ACCEPT.
DON'T FEED.

HEY, CAPTAIN
ZEN OVER HERE
SOUNDING ALL
MYSTIC AGAIN.

WE GET IT.
YOU SEE THE
LINE BETTER
THAN ALL OF US.
NO NEED TO
FLEX.

ズズ...

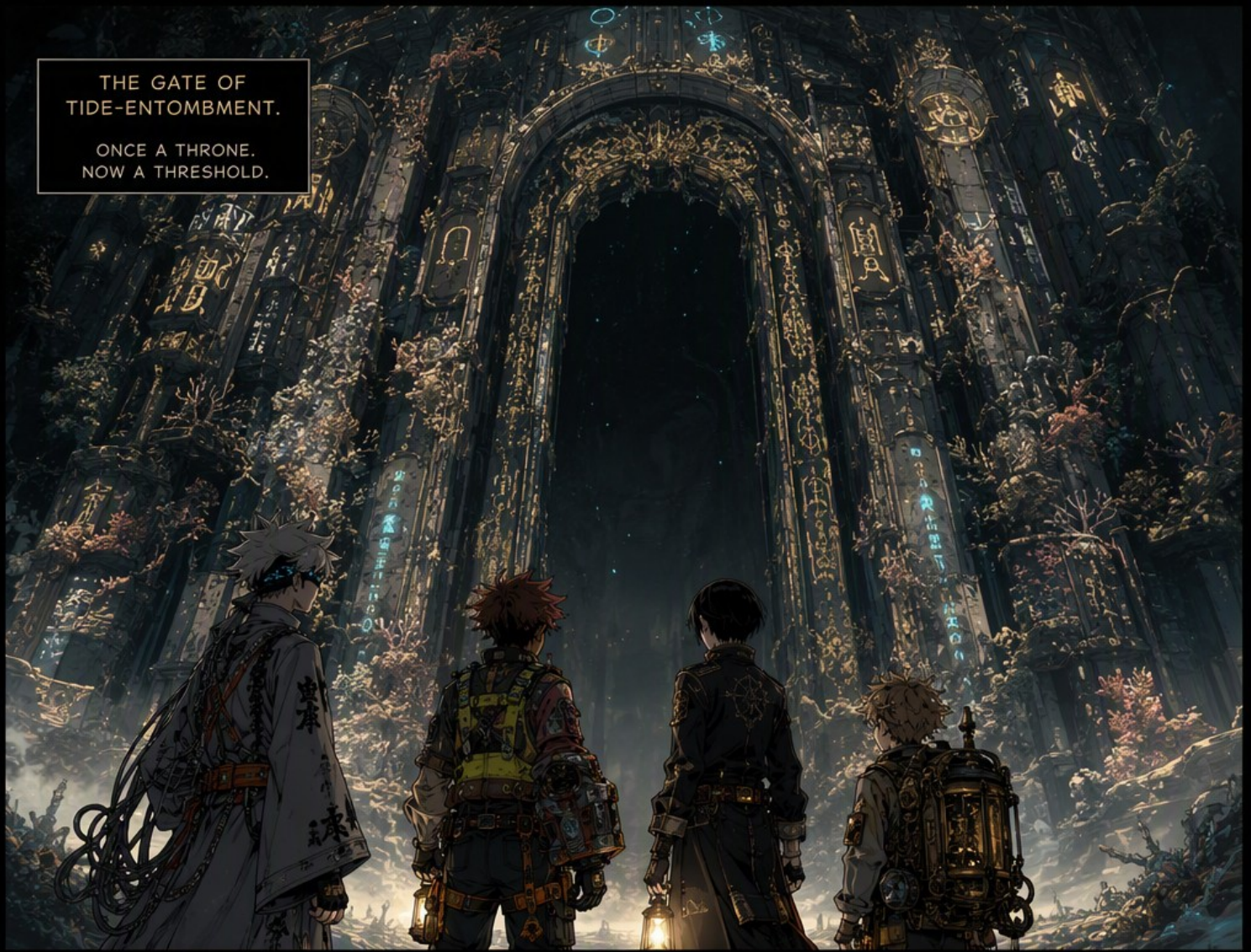
SILT DENSITY
INCREASING.
WATER CURRENT
SHIFTING DOWNWARD.
WE CLOSE IN.

WHATEVER
WE FIND
DOWN THERE...

...WE DON'T
LET IT FIND
US FIRST.

THE GATE OF
TIDE-ENTOMBMENT.

ONCE A THRONE.
NOW A THRESHOLD.



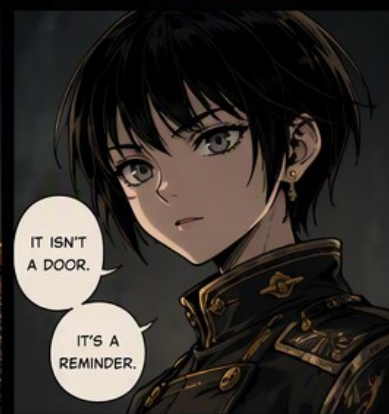
HEH.

BIGGEST
DOOR I'VE
EVER SEEN.



IT ISN'T
A DOOR.

IT'S A
REMINDER.



HOW LONG
WAS THIS
EVEN
OPEN?

D-DID
ANYONE
EVER
LEAVE?

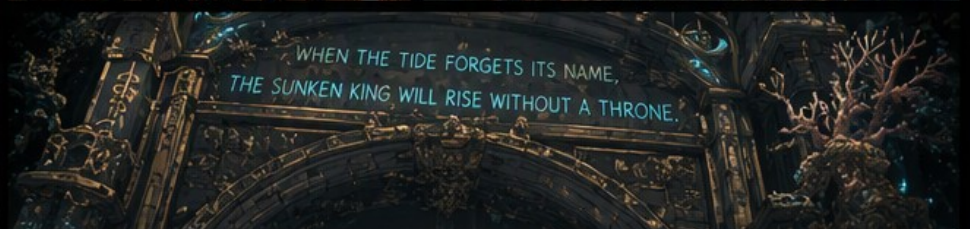


SOME
THINGS
DON'T OPEN.

THEY
AWAKEN.



WHEN THE TIDE FORGETS ITS NAME,
THE SUNKEN KING WILL RISE WITHOUT A THRONE.



THIS IS
AS FAR AS THE
SURVEY DRONES
WENT.

TILT
⚡

...ECHO?

WHAT IS IT?

SHHHHRRRP...

LISTEN.

SOMETHING'S
OUT THERE.

NOTHING VISIBLE.
JUST A RIPPLE IN
THE SILT. FAR OFF.

DEPTHS BELOW THE
DROWNED SPIRE
ANCHORITE HOLD
YEAR 1172 OF THE
SILT CALENDAR



HEY, ECHO.

YOU EVER GET
THE FEELING THESE
WAVES ARE...
MOVING?

THEY'RE
MURALS,
RENN.

NOT
OMENS.

B-BUT
THE WATER
DOWN HERE
DOES MOVE.

THE SILT
BREATHES.
MY CALCS
SAY SO.

FOCUS.

BREATH LIKE
THE DEPTHS.

FEEL BEFORE
YOU THINK.

THE DEEP
DOES NOT RUSH.
IT REMEMBERS.



THERE.

BEYOND THAT
COLLAPSE IS THE
OLD ANCHORITE
ARCHIVE.

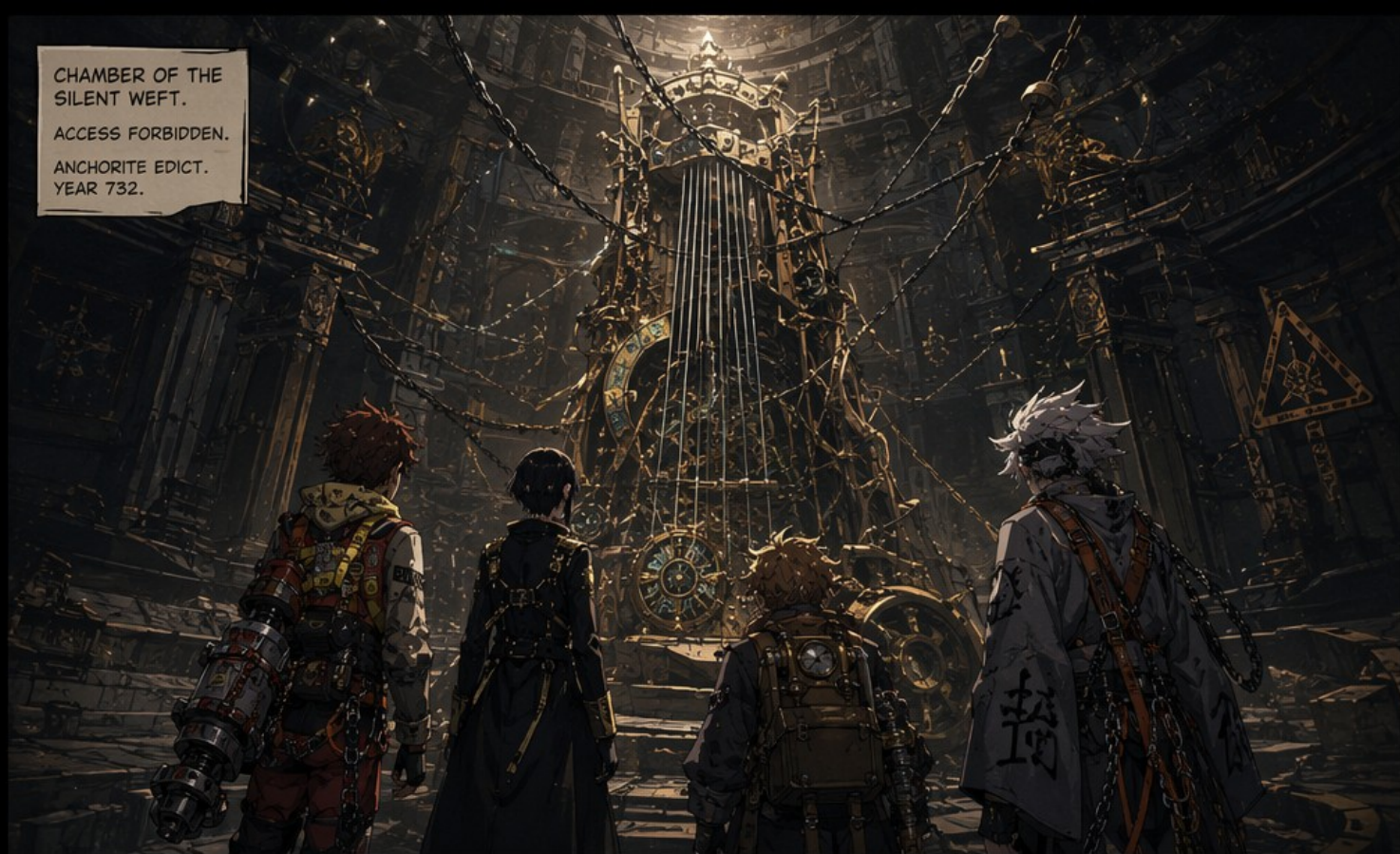
IF ANYONE
KNOWS WHAT
HAPPENED TO
THE SPIRE—
IT'S IN THERE.

...THEN OUR
ANSWERS ARE
BEHIND WHATEVER
SEALED THIS.

LET'S HOPE
IT STILL WANTS
TO SPEAK.



CHAMBER OF THE
SILENT WEFT.
ACCESS FORBIDDEN.
ANCHORITE EDICT.
YEAR 732.



...WHOA.



A WEFT-INSTRUMENT.
I'VE ONLY READ
ABOUT THESE.

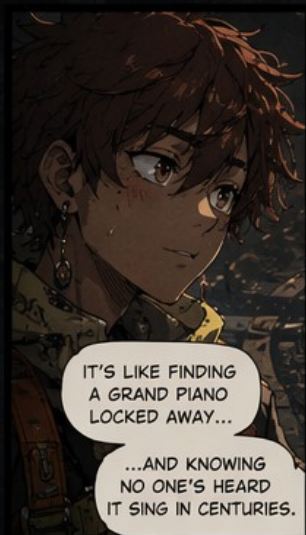


IT'S... IT'S
HUUUGE...
AND ALL THOSE
WARD-SEALS...



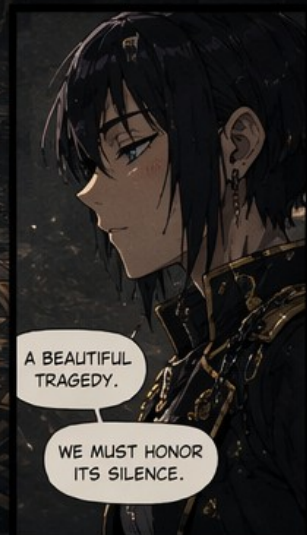
DORMANT.
BUT NOT DEAD.

SHE'S BEEN
WAITING.



IT'S LIKE FINDING
A GRAND PIANO
LOCKED AWAY...

...AND KNOWING
NO ONE'S HEARD
IT SING IN CENTURIES.



A BEAUTIFUL
TRAGEDY.

WE MUST HONOR
ITS SILENCE.

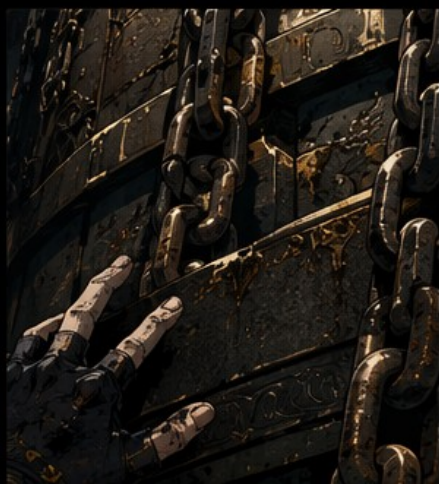
THE HEART
OF THE HARMONIUM.

BOUND BY THE
FIRST SONG.

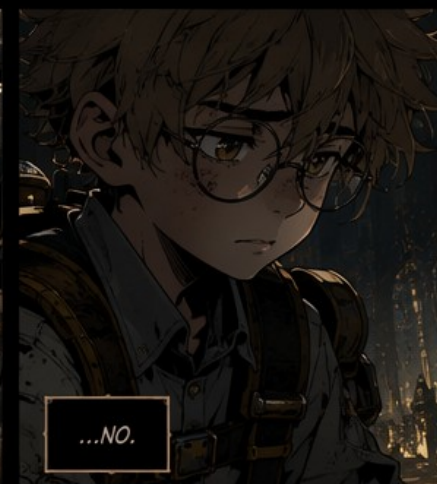
SILENT SINCE.



IT'S
BEAUTIFUL...



...NO.



WELL?
GONNA WAKE
THE GIANT?



NOT YET.

LET HIM
WATCH FIRST.



SOME SONGS
SHOULD NEVER
BE SUNG.

ONLY
REMEMBERED.



CHAMBER OF ETERNAL RESONANCE

— FORBIDDEN REALM OF THE
SILENT STRINGS

WITHIN THESE
DORMANT STRINGS,
A MELODY SLEEPS.

ECHO HEARS WHAT
OTHERS CANNOT.

A MELODY
OF PARTING.

OF PROMISE.

OF
SOMETHING
LOST.

RECOGNITION.

...OR
GRIEF.

NOT MUSIC.

MEMORY.

I WAS HERE
BEFORE.

OR PERHAPS...

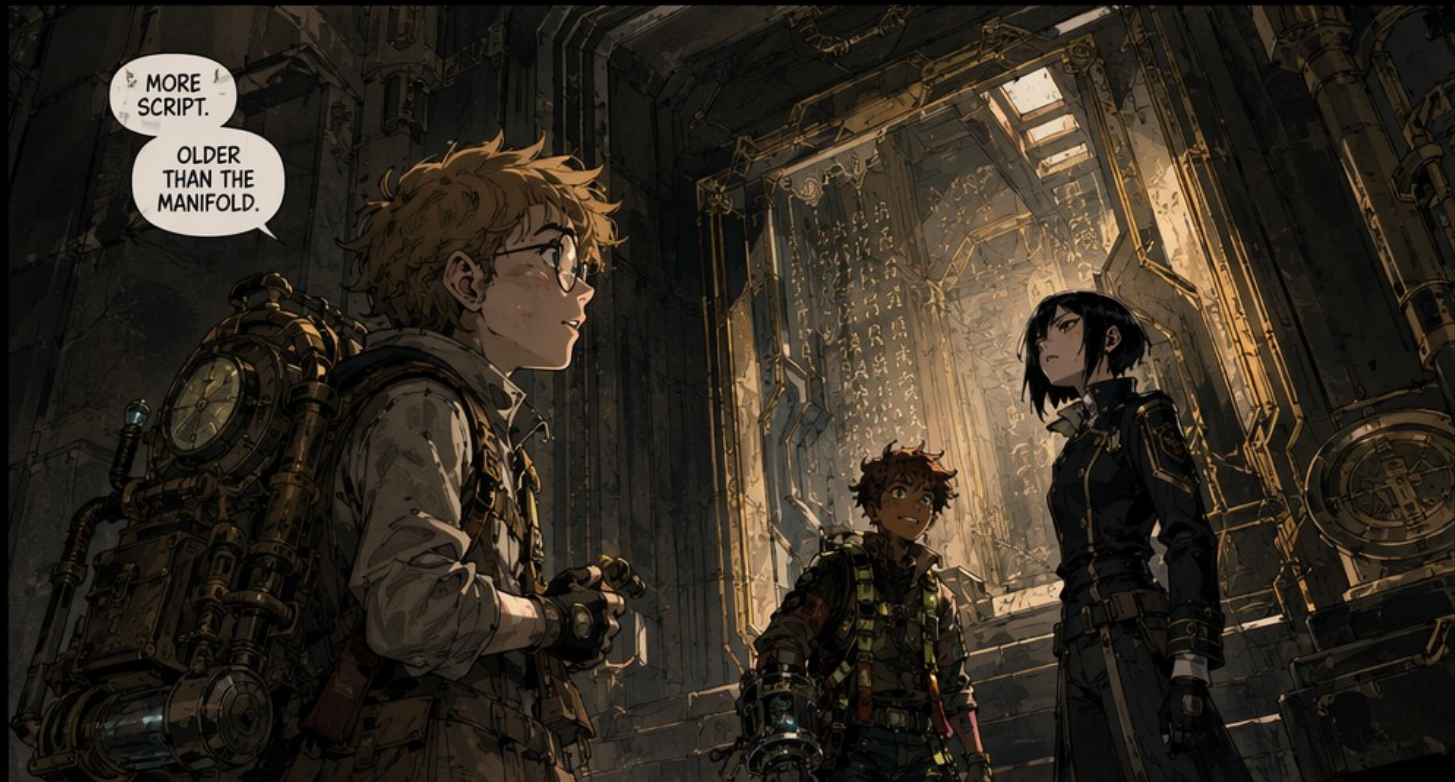
I LEFT
SOMETHING
BEHIND.

THE CHAMBER
REMEMBERS.

AND SO DO I.

ECHO // SEEKER OF SILENT TRUTHS





MORE
SCRIPT.

OLDER
THAN THE
MANIFOLD.



THERE—

KRIKT.

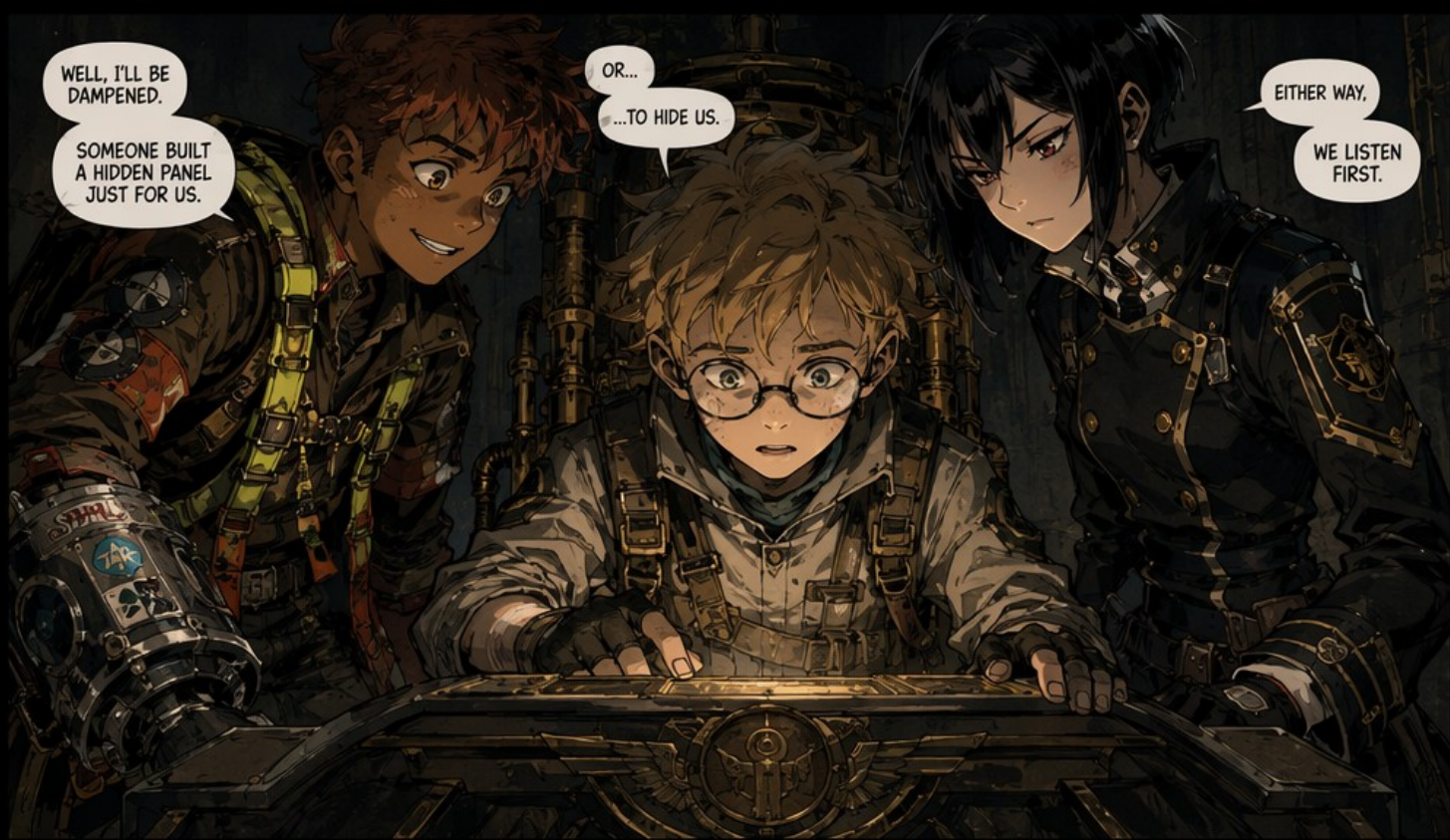


"A SECONDARY
CONSOLE.

BURIED,
BUT NOT
DEAD.



IT'S STILL
HOLDING
A SIGNAL...



WELL, I'LL BE
DAMPENED.

SOMEONE BUILT
A HIDDEN PANEL
JUST FOR US.

OR...

...TO HIDE US.

EITHER WAY,

WE LISTEN
FIRST.



THE WEAVERS
DID NOT MERELY
PLAY THE GREAT
INSTRUMENT...

...THEY BECAME
ITS HEARTBEAT.

TOGETHER.



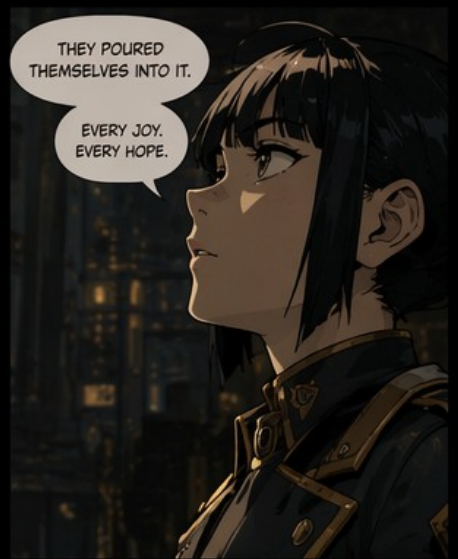
THE HARMONIC
LOOM... RESPONDS.

NOT TO COMMAND,
BUT TO UNITY.



THEY POURED
THEMSELVES INTO IT.

EVERY JOY.
EVERY HOPE.



TO THINK...
ALL THAT LIGHT.

LOCKED AWAY.



NOT DESTROYED.

JUST... PUT
OUT OF REACH.

LIKE A SONG
NO ONE'S ALLOWED
TO REMEMBER.



AND SO THE MUSIC
FADES, NOT IN SILENCE...

...BUT IN REMEMBRANCE.

THE ZENITH PLATES

FAR DEPTHS, ANCHORITE HOLD

CYCLE 7,892.17

SOME TRUTHS
AREN'T GIVEN.

THEY'RE EARNED.

So that's
what it was.

You okay?

The harmonic
resonance matches the plate etching
but—

Father didn't
bring me here for
penance.

He brought me
here to see.

The phase
alignment... it's
not natural.

Someone
calibrated it.

On purpose.

The Vanguard
didn't build this
to chain it.

They built it
to bind
something
else.

The Plates
aren't a prison.

They're
a key.

And we just
turned the
lock.

Told you
this place
had stories.

Stories are one
thing, Renn.

This is
inheritance.

And inheritance
demands a
choice.



RENN... WHAT HAPPENED
IN THE CELL?



HEH...
NOTHING
YOU NEED TO
WORRY ABOUT.



I'M NOT
ASKING TO
WORRY.

I'M ASKING
BECAUSE I... CARE
WHAT YOU CARRY
ALONE.



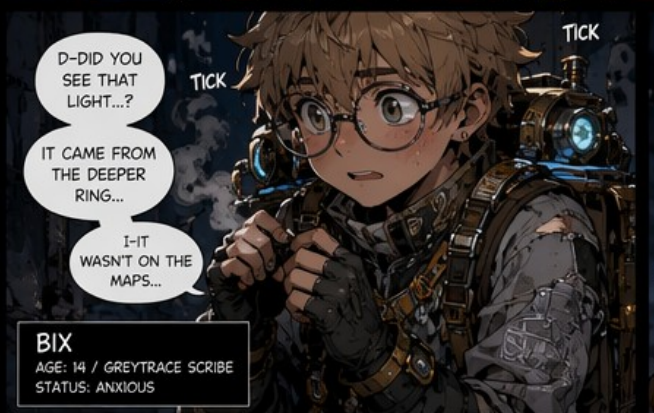
...YEAH.

THANKS,
SLOANE.



I WON'T
PUSH.

NOT NOW.



D-DID YOU
SEE THAT
LIGHT...?

TICK
IT CAME FROM
THE DEEPER
RING...

TICK
I-IT
WASN'T ON THE
MAPS...

BIX
AGE: 14 / GREYTRACE SCRIBE
STATUS: ANXIOUS



THE CHAMBER
BREATHES.

WHAT WE SAW
WAS ONLY AN
EXHALE.

ECHO
ROLE: PATHFINDER
STATUS: CALM / ALERT



THE DEEPER WE GO,
THE QUIETER IT GETS.

AND THE MORE IT
REMEMBERS.



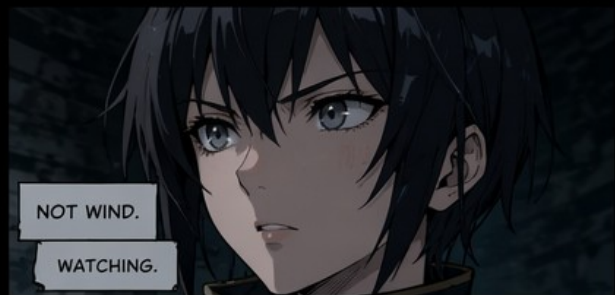
THE CHAMBER
DOESN'T LIKE
STILLNESS.

IT REMEMBERS
PRESSURE.
IT ANSWERS IT.



SILT RIPPLES.
NOT FROM BELOW.

SOMETHING
SHIFTED ABOVE.



NOT WIND.

WATCHING.



EVERYONE
UP.

NOW.





THE CONSOLE'S
QUIET. LET'S KEEP
IT THAT WAY.



JUST A FRAGMENT...
BUT IT'S ALL WE
NEED.



EXIT'S THAT
WAY.
STAIRS SHOULD
GET US TOPSIDE.



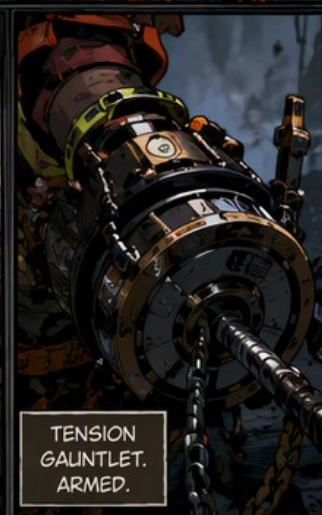
SLOPE'S
UNSTABLE. SINGLE
FILE.



I'LL GO
FIRST.
FOLLOW MY
LEAD.



SECURED.
NO RATTLE.
NO TRACE.



TENSION
GAUNTLET.
ARMED.



DISCIPLINE
IS SURVIVAL.



FOCUS.
BREATHE.
MOVE.



BEHIND US—
A GIANT THAT
SLEEPS.

AHEAD—
THE SURFACE.
AND WHAT
COMES NEXT.



WE TAKE
ONLY WHAT
WE NEED.

WE LEAVE
THE REST.

WE TURN
OUR BACKS ON
WHAT SHOULD
HAVE STAYED
BURIED.

THE MANTA'S
LIGHTS CALL
TO US LIKE
A PROMISE.

BEHIND US...

YOU FEEL
THAT?

I FEEL ITS
DISCIPLINE.

LIKE
SOMETHING'S
STRETCHING
RIGHT BEHIND
OUR NECKS.

IT WAITS.
IT DOES NOT
CHASE.

MY READINGS
ARE ALL OVER
THE PLACE—
PRESSURE
SPIKES,

SILT
DISTURBANCES,
MAGNETIC
FLUCTUATIONS—

IT'S BIG.
REALLY BIG.

THEN WE
GIVE IT NOTHING
TO FOLLOW.

NO SOUND.
NO TRAIL.
NO FEAR.

JUST
DIRECTION.

KKKHHH—

IT FOLLOWS
BECAUSE WE
TOUCHED WHAT
WE SHOULDN'T.

BUT WE DON'T
RUN.

WE RETURN.

END OF EPISODE



NEXT EPISODE: SHADOWS THAT REMAIN